

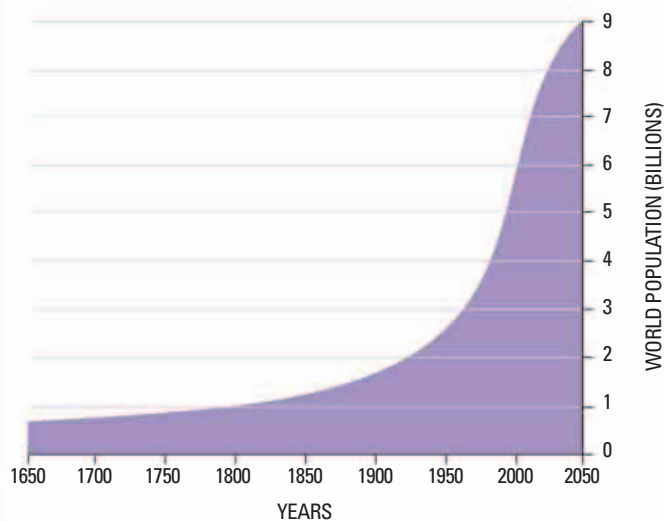


ENERGY AND POPULATION

In Europe before about 1800, many people lived on the land and in poverty. Soon, however, coal was fueling the new steam-powered technologies in factories. As industries grew, so did workforces and the cities they lived in. By 1900, technology for refining oil (in refineries such as this one, above) created a new source of energy that fueled modern economies and rapidly expanding populations.

POPULATION GROWTH

In 1800, there were about 1 billion people living on the planet. This increased to roughly 2.5 billion by 1950, 3 billion by 1960, 6 billion by 2000, and 7 billion today. Experts believe that the global population will reach 8 billion by 2030, and could even grow to a colossal 9 billion by 2050.



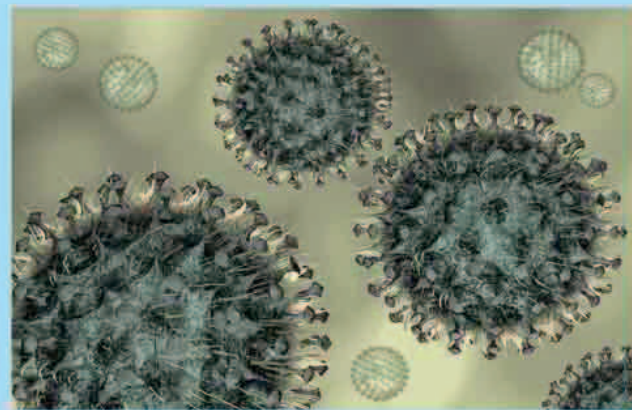
► TEEMING CROWDS

One of the busiest crosswalks in the world is in Tokyo, Japan. The city is home to about 8.9 million people.



FIGHTING DISEASE

Throughout history, plagues have killed millions of people. The Black Death of 1346–1353, for example, spread across Asia and Europe and killed up to 200 million people. Thanks to medical advances, people now survive diseases that were once fatal, and vaccines protect against infection—by 1979, vaccinations had eradicated the deadly disease smallpox. These advances have allowed populations to grow quickly.



▲ KILLER VIRUS

A magnified image shows the influenza virus. A worldwide flu epidemic in 1918–1920 killed up to 50 million people.

IS THERE A LIMIT?

If the world's population rises to nine billion by 2050, we will have to produce 70 percent more food to ensure that everyone has enough to eat. Some scientists warn that our increasing use of natural resources threatens the future of the world's ecosystem—the global community of living things and their environments. As we rely on this for our survival, we may be close to reaching the limit of human population.

